HILCHOT HANUKKAH – SHULHAN ARUKH

Al HaNissim, Hallel, Torah Reading & Hanukkah Away From Home

Hilchot Hanukkah I Siman 682–684

Dayan Daniel Kada · Thursday Night Halacha · Shiur 7 of 7, the final shiur Shulḥan Arukh, Oraḥ Ḥayim 682, 683, 684 and 677

This shiur was dedicated לעילוי נשמת יצחק בן אלכסנדר, and the Rabbi wished Maor a long life.

The Whole Course at a Glance

Siman	Topic
670	What may not be done on Hanukah
671	Where to place the menorah
672	When to light
673	Fuels
674	Lighting from one light to another
675	The lighting makes the mitzvah, not the placing
676	The order of the berachot and the direction of lighting; the berachah on seeing
678	Shabbat candles take precedence over Hanukah lights when money is short
679	Friday: light Hanukah first
680	Don't place it where the door will blow it out on Shabbat
681	Havdalah: in shul, menorah first; at home, the Sephardi practice is Havdalah first

Tonight: 682, 683 and 684, then **677**, travelling and being a guest on Hanukah, "and we will complete Hilchot Hanukah this evening."

Siman 682: Al HaNissim

Seif 1: Where it is said, and what if you forget

כל שמונת ימי חנוכה אומרים על הנסים בברכת המזון בברכת הארץ, ובתפלה בברכת מודים. ואם לא אמר, אין מחזירין אותו.

Why in those places? Hanukah is all about **הלל והודאה**, praise and **thanksgiving**. So **Al HaNissim** goes where we give thanks: - In the Amidah, in **מודים** ("We thank You"). - In Birkat HaMazon, in **נודה לך** ("We thank You").

Contrast the festivals and Rosh Ḥodesh, whose additions (**רצה והחליצנו**, **יעלה ויבא**) go into the third berachah, **רחם**.

Why not repeat if forgotten? The Gemara itself says one *may* include it, but doesn't have to. It does not have the status of **יעלה ויבא** on the festivals and Rosh Ḥodesh.

Why not in Al HaMiḥyah?

In **על המחיה** we add a mention of the **festivals** (the three regalim and Rosh HaShanah) and of **Rosh Ḥodesh**, but nothing for **Hanukah or Purim**. Why?

A simple answer fails: "Only biblical days get an addition." But **Rosh Ḥodesh** is mentioned (**וזכרנו לטובה ביום ראש החדש הזה**) and is rabbinic in its commemoration, though one could argue its concept is biblical.

The Rishonim note that the **Yerushalmi** implies we *should* add it, and some Aḥaronim, including **R. Ḥayim Palagi**, did include Hanukah and Purim in Al HaMiḥyah, "believe it or not." The Rabbi knows of no community that does so today.

Three explanations:

1. Tosafot: frequency. Al HaMiḥyah is said less often than the Amidah and Birkat HaMazon, so no addition was instituted. *But* that doesn't explain Rosh Ḥodesh and the festivals.

2. Structure. Follow the text: - **על המחיה ועל הכלכלה ועל תנובת השדה**: sustenance (= Birkat HaMazon's first berachah). - **ועל ארץ חמדה טובה ורחבה...**: the land (= the second berachah, **נודה לך... על ארץ**). - **רחם נא...**: mercy (= the third berachah).

There is **no explicit "we thank You"** in Al HaMiḥyah. Additions normally go after **רחם**, before **ובנה ירושלים**, which suits **רצה** and **יעלה ויבא**. Al HaNissim belongs in a **thanksgiving** passage, and there is none, so inserting it would be an interruption.

3. The Brisker Rav, the Rabbi's favourite: - Al HaMiḥyah's real name is **ברכה מעין שלש**, a single berachah **summarising** Birkat HaMazon. Really four berachot, since **כי אתה טוב ומטיב** reflects the fourth, but Birkat HaMazon's core is the first three, up to **בונה ירושלים אמן**. - **A little-known law:** if you forgot **יעלה ויבא** in Birkat HaMazon and remember **after בונה ירושלים אמן but before starting the fourth berachah**, you insert **a special berachah**: **ברוך אתה ה'... שנתן ראשי חדשים לעמו ישראל לזכרון ימים טובים...** (or **...**). (If you remember before saying Hashem's name in בונה ירושלים, go back to **רחם**. If you have begun the fourth berachah, even just "ברוך," it's too late.) Many siddurim omit it because it is so rarely needed. - So **Rosh Ḥodesh and the festivals can generate a berachah of their own** within Birkat HaMazon, which is why the **summary** berachah mentions them. - **Al HaNissim never generates a berachah of its own.** Forget it and that's it. So it has no place in the summary.

"על הנסים" or "ועל הנסים"?

Ashkenazim say **ועל הנסים**, as does the **S&P siddur** (and, the Rabbi understands, Ḥacham Ovadia), with the *vav* showing that it continues the preceding thanksgiving. **Most Sephardi siddurim** say **על הנסים**. "So, Ashkenazim do it [too], so that's what I do."

When you are obliged to repeat Birkat HaMazon

The general principle: where there is an **obligation to eat a se'udah**, forgetting to mention the day means **repeating**. Where there is no obligation, you don't (with some exceptions).

Meal	Forgot רצה?
Friday night	**Everyone agrees: repeat**
Shabbat lunch	Debated; depends on the timing of the meal
Se'udah shelishit	**Don't repeat**. Some kabbalists, and the Ben Ish Ḥai, say to go back

Shabbat Ḥanukah: you said רצה but forgot Al HaNissim. Repeat? **No.** The Friday-night meal obligation is **because of Shabbat, not Hanukah**, and you mentioned Shabbat. (If you forgot **רצה**, of course you repeat, saying both.)

Before Hashem's name, go back

ומיהו אם נזכר באותה ברכה, כל זמן שלא הזכיר את השם, אפילו נזכר בין "אתה" ל"ה'", חוזר. If you remember **before saying Hashem's name** in that berachah (**ברוך אתה** and **ה'**, even between), go back to **נודה לך** or **מודים** and include it. After the name, you don't go back.

The Rema: a substitute in הרחמן

יש אומרים: if you forgot Al HaNissim in Birkat HaMazon, then at the **הרחמן** section add:

הרחמן הוא יעשה לנו נסים ונפלאות כשם שעשה לאבותינו בימים ההם בזמן הזה. בימי מתתיהו...

The poskim write that the same applies to the **Amidah**: in **אלקי נצור**, add **יהי רצון... שתעשה לנו נסים... בימי מתתיהו...**

Why there? - **Birkat HaMazon formally ends** with the fourth berachah: **ולעולם מכל טוב אל יחסרנו**. The **הרחמן** requests are an addition. After thanking Hashem for food it is a **favourable moment** (**עת רצון**) to ask, as **Yitzḥak** wished to bless Esav once he had eaten and was satisfied. Speaking at that point is not an interruption. - **The Amidah formally ends** at **המברך את עמו ישראל בשלום**: we answer **אמן** to mark the end of a series of berachot. **אלקי נצור** comes after.

May we ask for miracles?

The Gemara's principle: one may **not** ask for a miracle. It is **chutzpah** to ask the Holy One to change **סדרי מעשה בראשית**, the order of creation. So how can we say **הרחמן הוא יעשה לנו נסים**?

1. **Some Aḥaronim:** the prohibition is for **an individual**. Including yourself **among Am Yisrael**, "make **us** miracles," is permitted.
2. **A more Ḥasidic idea:** Hanukah is **a time of miracles**, and its **aura** allows one to ask. The **Ben Ish Ḥai** writes that women would make vows in the merit of Hanukah.

The spiral staircase: "Jewish festivals are not just historical commemorations, they are reliving the events." Picture a **spiral staircase**: each year we go higher, but we return to the same point in the circle. That is why the month of Av is meant to be a difficult time: we are not just remembering, we are reliving it. Likewise we relive Hanukah, **a time of nissim and nifla'ot**, so it is fitting to ask for miracles.

Seif 2: Musaf

גם במוסף של שבת ושל ראש חודש צריך להזכיר של חנוכה, אף על פי שאין מוסף בחנוכה. Al HaNissim is included in **Musaf** of Shabbat and Rosh Ḥodesh, although Hanukah has no Musaf of its own.

Seif 3: Don't end with a request

אין אומרים "כשם שעשית לאבותינו כך תעשה לנו נסים", אלא מסיים "ועשית עמהם נסים ונפלאות..."

The **Beit Yosef** notes a variant text that ended Al HaNissim with **"as You did miracles for our fathers, so do miracles for us."** The Shulḥan Arukh rules **not to say it**. Why?

- **A suggested reason:** we don't ask for things in the **last three berachot** of the Amidah.
- **The Beit Yosef rejects that:** during the **Ten Days of Repentance** we add requests there, because the restriction applies to **personal** requests, while **communal** needs may be asked even in the first and last three.
- **His real reason: it contradicts the berachah we are in. Modim** is **הודאה**, thanksgiving, which is always about **the past**.

"Sometimes people thank you for something and then ask you for something straight away afterwards, and then you recognise that the thanksgiving was never actually to say thanks. The thanks was just an introduction to be able to ask for the next thing." Hoda'ah is **על לשעבר**, for the past, and so Al HaNissim ends with thanks alone.

Siman 683: Hallel

כל שמונת ימי חנוכה גומרין את ההלל. *All eight days of Hanukah we say the complete Hallel.*

Why full Hallel every day of a rabbinic festival, when Pesaḥ has full Hallel only at the start? The Gemara: **each day of Hanukah was a new miracle**. The oil lasted another day, every day.

Festival	Full Hallel	Why
Pesaḥ	First day(s) only	**One** miracle, the Exodus. (The **seventh day** brought the splitting of the sea, a new miracle, but we don't say full Hallel "when the Egyptians were drowning")
Sukkot	Every day	A **different sacrifice** was offered each day
Hanukah	**Every day**	**A new dimension of the miracle each day**

Women and Hallel on Hanukah

(The Rabbi has discussed this at length in the **Daily Halacha** series.) The Rishonim discuss whether women say Hallel on Hanukah.

	Ruling
Sephardim (Shulḥan Arukh)	Women should **not say a berachah** on Hallel. **It is good practice** for them to say the full Hallel all eight days, **without a berachah**
Ashkenazim	Not obligated, but **may** say it, **even with a berachah**
Sephardi communities with their own custom	The **Spanish & Portuguese**, many in **Morocco**, and, surprisingly, even in **Iraq**, women **did** bless on time-bound mitzvot (arba minim, shofar), against the Shulḥan Arukh. If that is your family's custom, continue it, including Hallel on Hanukah

Absent a known custom, Sephardim follow the Shulḥan Arukh: **no berachah** for women on time-bound positive mitzvot.

The Rema: throughout Hanukah we omit **Taḥanun**, **Seliḥot**, **Tzidduk HaDin**, and **צדקתך** at Shabbat Minḥah.

Siman 684: The Torah Reading

Seif 1: The Nesi'im

Each day we read from **Parashat Naso**: the **קורין בקרבנות הנשיאים שבפרשת נשא, שלשה בכל יום.** offerings of the princes at the dedication of the Mishkan. **Three are called up.**

Why the Nesi'im? Back to **the four aspects of Hanukah** from the very first shiur: 1. **The military victory**: Hallel and Al HaNissim (**הלל והודאה**). 2. **The oil**: the menorah, and oily foods (a much later custom). 3. **Yehudit**, daughter of Yoḥanan Kohen Gadol, who fed a Greek ruler dairy, put him to sleep and killed him, which began the victory: dairy foods (a very late custom). 4. **The Mishkan**: it was ready on **25 Kislev**, but Hashem said, "Let's leave it till Nisan, the month the world was created," and it was inaugurated on Rosh Ḥodesh Nisan. Kislev was disappointed, so Hashem said, "**I'll repay you, and give you Hanukah later on.**"

That fits Hanukah's core meaning, **re-inauguration**: on recapturing the Temple, the Ḥashmonaim had to purify it, clean it out and restart the service. So we read the Nesi'im's inauguration of **the very first Mishkan**, about 3,000 years ago.

The number of aliyot reveals the holiness

The Ramḥal (Derech Hashem):

Aliyot	Day	Why
7	**Shabbat**	The holiest
6	**Yom Kippur**	No work, like Shabbat, but a lesser punishment for violation
5	**Festivals and Rosh HaShanah**	Work for food is permitted
4	**Rosh Ḥodesh**, **Ḥol HaMoed**	
3	**Hanukah, Purim**	

"People make a whole great thing out of Hanukah and Purim, but actually the holiness of **Rosh Ḥodesh** is seemingly greater." Hanukah comes once a year, so we get excited; Rosh Ḥodesh comes every month, "so you don't have the same enthusiasm for it. But really, Rosh Ḥodesh is a very special time."

Beginning with Birkat Kohanim

but on the first day ,**ויהי ביום כלות משה להקים את המשכן** The Nesi'im begin at **.ומתחילין בברכת כהנים** .**Sephardim begin a few verses earlier, with Birkat Kohanim**

Why? The victory came about **through Kohanim**: **Mattityahu**, **Yoḥanan Kohen Gadol**. The Kohanim served in the Temple and seemed the least able to fight, yet they led the victory.

Ashkenazim begin with the .(the Rema) **ויש אומרים שמתחילין "ויהי ביום כלות משה", וכן אנו נוהגין** .Nesi'im

How the aliyot are split: - **Sephardim:** the Kohen and Levi divide **the day's prince**, and the **Yisrael re-reads that day's prince** in full. And so every day. - **Ashkenazim:** the third aliyah reads **the next day's** prince. - **The eighth day:** from the eighth prince **to the end of the section**.

Seif 2: Shabbat Ḥanukah

Two Sifrei Torah: the weekly parashah, and the day's prince. **Haftarah: רני ושמחי** (Zechariah), with his vision of **a golden menorah**. On a **second** Shabbat Ḥanukah (when the first and eighth days are both Shabbat), the Haftarah is from **Melachim**: Shlomo and the lamps of the Temple.

Seif 3: Three Sifrei Torah

When **Shabbat, Rosh Ḥodesh and Hanukah** coincide: **three Sifrei Torah**. The only times in the year (besides Simḥat Torah) are **Shabbat Rosh Ḥodesh Ṭevet during Hanukah**, and **Shabbat Rosh Ḥodesh** coinciding with **Shekalim** or **HaḤodesh**.

Siman 677: The Guest and the Traveller

Seif 1: Contributing to the host's oil

A guest for whom **אכסנאי שאין מדליקין עליו בתוך ביתו, צריך ליתן פרוטה לבעל הבית להשתתף עמו בשמן.** *.no one is lighting at home must give the host a perutah to become a partner in the oi*

Who is a "guest"? The key is eating AND sleeping there.

Situation	Status	What to do
You live, sleep and eat with the host for all eight days	**Part of the household**	**Nothing.** Sephardim light one menorah per household, and the host's lighting covers you
Just one night, e.g. Shabbat with family	**Not** part of the household (near-universal view)	**Light in your own home** Friday afternoon, and again on Saturday night when you're back
Several nights (two, three, four)	**Unclear**	**Best practice: contribute** to the host's oil
Sleeping there but eating your own food (renting a room, or yeshivah students in the past who boarded only for meals or beds)	**Not** part of the household	**Light yourself**, or **contribute** to the host's oil

A common case: a young couple stays with **the in-laws** for **Shabbat Ḥanukah**, three nights. Sleeping and eating there, but not for all eight days, so they should contribute.

Instead of paying, the Mishnah Berurah allows the host to **give you** a share, but it must be a **formal acquisition** of a portion of the oil.

Only if no one lights for you at home

All this applies **only if no one is lighting for you at home.** - A **yeshivah student** boarding in a house is covered by **his parents** at home. - **A business traveller** staying with a friend, out for business meals all day, is covered by **his wife lighting at home**.

Your own entrance

> **ואם יש לו פתח פתוח לעצמו, צריך להדליק בפתחו**: someone with **their own entrance** (a self-contained studio beside the house) must **light there**, even if they eat at the host's table, **because of חשד** (suspicion).

The Rema: nowadays, when we light **indoors**, suspicion doesn't apply, so you **light where you eat**, and that is the custom.

Mark asked: can't they just light in their own room? **The Rabbi:** of course, if they have a place to light (ideally a window facing the street), they may light there **with a berachah**, provided no one lights for them at home. The contribution is for someone who wants to be **included** in the household's lighting.

Time differences and "opting out"

Two questions, which combine:

1. Time differences. Parents in the UK, student in Israel: **two hours** ahead. At 5 pm in Israel it is 3 pm in London, but when the parents light at 5 pm it is 7 pm in Israel. **Fine.** But **America and Israel: seven hours**. By the time the parents light, the student is asleep. Can you really rely on that?

2. Opting out. Can a traveller or yeshivah student say, "**I don't want to be included** in my household's lighting," so as to light and bless independently?

	Opting out
The Rema	**Yes**, you can
The Beit Yosef (in the Mishnah Berurah)	**No.** Your parents support you, pay your flights and expenses, or you live with your spouse. "You can't say 'I'm not part of that.' Of course you are"

ḤHacham Ovadia's synthesis (ספק ספקא): neither factor alone is enough. **But with both together**, a **significant** time difference (not one or two hours; five or seven, "use your common sense") **and** an explicit intention to exclude yourself, **you may light your own menorah with the berachot.** Even for Australia, the basic premise is that you are part of the household; only the combination allows your own berachah. (You may always light without a berachah.)

The whole household travels: the hotel

A couple with no children left at home: the household **moves with them**. Staying with people for all eight days, they are part of that household. For part of Hanukah, they contribute or receive a formal gift of the oil.

But a hotel that allows lighting neither in the room nor in the lobby? What can they do?

A participant's story: on a flight to **Australia**, losing a day, they **lit in the airline lounge**. An air hostess came and told them to put it out; they said they couldn't, and either she left it or blew it out herself. They had been told by a rabbi that **a relative** in the States or in London could **light on their behalf, keeping them in mind**.

The Rabbi: "I'm not entirely clear how that works." **You must be part of the household.** It is **נר איש וביתו**. You can't simply have someone keep you in mind. Unless you genuinely support that household and its food, "that's a different question."

So if you truly cannot light: fall back on **ברכת הרואה**, the berachah on seeing. Walk down a Jewish street and, seeing a menorah, say **שעשה נסים** (and **שהחיינו** on the first night). Not **להדליק**.

Seif 2: A child

A child at home is covered by the parents. **Even Ashkenazim**, where **קטן שהגיע לחינוך צריך להדליק.** each person lights, customarily do so only **from bar/bat mitzvah**.

Seif 3: Somewhere with no Jews

even if your home lights for you, **in a place with no Jews** you light with berachot. "This is a :**יש אומרים** very troublesome halacha, because it contradicts what we've learned." There are answers; the Rabbi left it.

The Rema adds: even among Jews, someone who wants to be **stringent** may light and bless. As explained above, the Mishnah Berurah brings the **Beit Yosef**'s disagreement, **and we don't do this.**

Seif 4: Leftover oil after the eighth night

A **bottle** of olive - **הנותר ביום השמיני מן השמן הצריך לשיעור הדלקה, עושה לו מדורה ושורפו בפני עצמו.** oil you hadn't put into the menorah is just oil. Use it however you like. - **Leftover oil in the menorah** on nights one to seven can be used **the next night**. - **On the eighth night:** oil set aside for **the required half hour**, left over because the light went out early, is **הוקצה למצותו**, set aside for the mitzvah. It may not be

used for anything else and must be **burned on its own**. - Oil beyond the half hour (you filled it for two hours and it burned for one) is ordinary. Do what you like with it.

Summary

1. **Al HaNissim** goes in the **thanksgiving** berachot (Modim; Nodeh Lecha), because Hanukah is **הלל והודאה**. **Forgot it? Don't repeat**, but go back if Hashem's name has not yet been said. **Substitute** in **הרחמן** or **אלקי נצור**.
2. **Not in Al HaMiḥyah:** the **Brisker Rav**: it is a **summary** berachah, and Al HaNissim, unlike **יעלה ויבא**, never generates a berachah of its own.
3. **Shabbat Ḥanukah:** said **רצה** but forgot Al HaNissim? **Don't repeat**: the meal obligation is Shabbat's.
4. **Asking for miracles** is normally chutzpah. It is permitted as **a community**, and in **a season of miracles** we relive each year (**the spiral staircase**). But **don't end Al HaNissim with a request**: thanksgiving is for **the past**.
5. **Full Hallel all eight days:** a **new miracle every day**. Sephardi women: Hallel **without a berachah**, unless their community's custom is to bless.
6. **Torah reading:** the **Nesi'im** (re-inauguration). **Three aliyot**, fewer than Rosh Ḥodesh (the Ramḥal's scale). Sephardim **open with Birkat Kohanim**, for the Kohanim who led the victory. Shabbat: two Sifrei Torah, **רני ושמחי**; with Rosh Ḥodesh, three.
7. **Guests:** living, sleeping and eating there for all eight days means you are covered. One night: light at home. In between: **contribute to the oil**. All only if **no one lights for you at home**.
8. **Opting out of your household's lighting:** only with **both** a large **time difference** and **explicit intent** (Ḥacham Ovadia).
9. **A hotel where you cannot light:** you cannot be covered by relatives' homes. Use the **berachah on seeing**.
10. **Leftover oil** from the eighth night's **required half hour** must be **burned on its own**.

Conclusion

to everyone. "This is the end of Hilchot Hanukah. I'm delighted we've been able to get through it **חזק וברוך** all."

The course resumed in **2025**, with a **WhatsApp poll** on the topic: **Hilchot Pesaḥ** (a significant part, perhaps half, "if we really work hard") or **all of Hilchot Purim**, in time for Purim.

Ḥanukah Same'aḥ.

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